

Leading Innovation and Navigating Crisis: An Organizational Behavior Analysis of Pfizer's Top Management Team

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Introduction

Pfizer's journey through the COVID-19 pandemic was not just a triumph of science — it was a real-time demonstration of how effective **organizational behavior (OB)** can drive meaningful impact in moments of uncertainty. As one of the largest pharmaceutical companies in the world, Pfizer's performance under crisis conditions provides a rich case study to examine OB principles in action, as outlined in Robbins and Judge (2019).

In under 9 months, Pfizer went from genomic sequencing of the novel coronavirus to receiving the first FDA Emergency Use Authorization (EUA) for a COVID-19 vaccine — an achievement that normally takes 5–10 years. Behind this scientific feat was a deeply coordinated network of people, teams, structures, and leadership decisions. This report analyzes Pfizer's Top Management Team (TMT) through the lens of OB, integrating real-world data, peer-reviewed sources, and core textbook theories.

We explore **how transformational leadership, team dynamics, motivation strategies, ethical decision-making, communication models, diversity and inclusion, and organizational change** frameworks helped Pfizer lead not only scientifically, but organizationally. Our analysis highlights 10+ OB concepts from at least five chapters in Robbins and Judge (2019), each marked in **bold** upon first use. By connecting theory with lived corporate execution, we show how OB principles provided the behavioral backbone for one of the most consequential business operations in recent memory.

Transformational Leadership & Vision

At the heart of the response to the pandemic at Pfizer was the unshakeable and courageous leadership of CEO Albert Bourla, whose actions are an exemplary of **transformational leadership** (Chapter 12). Transformational leaders, Robbins and Judge (2019) describe, inspire followers to dedicate themselves to a shared vision, to challenge existing practices, and to enhance performance. Bourla did all this and more in guiding Pfizer through its fastest, highest-stakes product development in history.

One of Bourla's earliest and most consequential decisions was to proceed with vaccine development using Pfizer's own funds — a \$2 billion internal investment — without upfront government contracts. These activities reflected conviction and **idealized influence**, and conviction and determination were embodied by Bourla. He galvanized global teams along the mantra, "Science will win," an **inspiration flag**, and it served to frame the pandemic as a scientific and ethical endeavor and, not just a business objective.

Pfizer's decision to partner with BioNTech, the small German biotech company which had established mRNA technology, was one taken on grounds of **bounded rationality** (Chapter 6). Under extreme pressure of time and without complete information, the TMT took an informed decision on the partner who had the right platform based on available information — an evident manifestation of decision theory in real life.

Bourla also promoted risk-taking and out-of-the-box thinking on a calculated basis by investing in **intellectual stimulation** among teams. Pfizer's R&D and regulatory teams, for instance, were motivated to defy the conventional expectations surrounding the order of vaccine

trials, condensing timelines by running stages simultaneously. This reorganization resulted in the first mRNA vaccine to be approved by the FDA in less than 248 days.

No less crucial was his habit of **one-on-one attention**. Through virtual town halls and internal messages, Bourla publicly acknowledged employee sacrifices and mental stress. Managers were empowered to reach out to employees individually, provide flexibility, and care as much about well-being as about performance. In the internal Pulse Survey conducted at Pfizer (2021), the employees reported that well over 84% were “valued by leadership” — an incredible statistic during an era of global burnout.

Team Dynamics and Communication – Moving as One

Whereas top leadership established the direction, the actual implementation was by autonomous, well-coordinated, and agile teams — the very classic hallmark of **self-managed teams** (Chapter 9: Foundations of Group Behavior). Rather than command-and-control structures, the COVID-19 vaccine effort in Pfizer was organized using **cross-functional units** with clear objectives but the autonomy to decide in the moment. The units were R&D, manufacturing, regulatory affairs, legal compliance, supply chain, and digital operations.

This allowed Pfizer to operate at record pace. For example, decisions that once took weeks — such as site selection for manufacturing or trial adjustment on interim data — were made in hours, thanks to the elimination of traditional siblings. The application of **high-performance team models**, as described by Robbins and Judge (2019), played an important role in creating psychological safety, trust, and ownership within its members.

The primary enabler of such performance was the **open communication** focus at Pfizer (Chapter 11: Communication). Weekly global town halls kept the entire organization on the same page, and Microsoft Teams and Slack-enabled daily functional check-ins allowed the course to be quickly corrected. Real-time dashboards and shared databases as the **one source of truth** were also enabled at Pfizer, with minimal space for miscommunication and duplicated effort — the common bottlenecks under high-pressure conditions.

Most importantly, the organization promoted **psychological safety** — where members were able to speak up, question assumptions, and accept responsibility for errors without fear of backlash. This concept, backed by Amy Edmondson's research and supported in Robbins and Judge's communication chapter, was vital in maintaining team performance and morale during the 12–18-month crunch window.

Internally, Pfizer's leadership also worked to sustain role clarity. Each team understood their deliverables but had the latitude to experiment with “how” they delivered them. This balance of autonomy-structure fits into **effective team norm theory** where the behavior is less controlled by top-down hierarchy and more by shared expectations.

The results speak for themselves: Pfizer cut its standard R&D-to-market lead time by over 85%, and internal team collaboration satisfaction was 22% higher than pre-pandemic (Pfizer ESG Report, 2022).

Motivation and Culture – The Why That Drives the How

Under prolonged stress, long hours, and global uncertainty, what kept the employees at Pfizer going in their endeavor? The answer was an **extrinsic and intrinsic motivation blend** (Chapter 7: Motivation), to align employee values and organizational sense of purpose. Motivation, according to Robbins and Judge (2019), is at an optimal level when the work setting provides autonomy, mastery, and purpose – which were intentionally crafted at Pfizer in its COVID-19 response.

Intrinsic Motivation:

Pfizer leaders cast the vaccine pursuit as a service to humanity — a **cause-driven crusade** to “bring hope to the world.” Workers did not see themselves as biotech bureaucrats but as servants of public health and life-saving sciences. This alignment is tracked with **self-determination theory**, which emphasizes internal sources of motivation such as competence, relatedness, and autonomy. Employee surveys at Pfizer in 2021 showed 88% of the Pfizer employees felt the work was “meaningful” — a very good measure of **intrinsic motivation** at scale.

Extrinsic Motivation:

But intrinsic meaning still wasn't enough. **Extrinsic rewards** were also built in by Pfizer, such as equity bonuses, performance-based recognition, paid extra leave, and career advancement opportunities. These align with **expectancy theory**, the idea that workers are motivated because they can clearly see links between effort, performance, and reward. **Goal-setting theory** was also integrated into everyday workstreams by Pfizer: all cross-functional

teams had stretch but measurable KPIs tied to such things as dose output, clinical milestones, or safety targets.

McClelland's theory of needs:

Pfizer's motivation strategy followed **McClelland's need theory** very closely, both **need for achievement** as well as **need for affiliation**. The employees were not just expected to deliver — but to work together, develop connections, and be the best in expertise. Even the company did internal storytelling campaigns where employees were recording “Why I show up” videos, recapturing shared values and social identity.

Cultural Reinforcement:

More broadly, there was an **overall company culture** at Pfizer (Chapter 16) centered around science, urgency, and integrity. These values were regularly communicated through virtual town halls, company publications, and management check-ins on a regular basis. The culture itself was an influence — influencing behavior through formal and informal rewards and social norms.

Therefore, retention during the pandemic peak was higher than the industry averages, and staff engagement was 18% higher than in 2019 (Pfizer ESG Report, 2022).

Ethical Leadership and Conflict Resolution – Upholding Values Under Pressure

At times of global crisis, ethical decision-making is not only the corporate responsibility but also the strategic necessity. **Ethical leadership** (Chapter 14: Leadership and Trust) guided

the company through crisis management in the context of the issue of vaccine equity, public accountability, and internal safety procedures. Robbins and Judge (2019) summarize ethical leaders as promoting fairness, transparency, and ethical values through action and procedure – all of which were reflected in the consistency of Albert Bourla and the Pfizer TMT.

Ethical Concerns and Resolution:

Pfizer has faced criticism regarding the price and IP rights of its vaccine. While others, including Moderna, were attacked by lawsuits and loss of reputation, at least, Pfizer decided to sell its vaccine at cost to poorer nations through the COVAX facility. This is an example of **utilitarian ethics** — the greatest good to the greatest number.

Internally, there were also ethical dilemmas wherein **safety and pace** had to be balanced by teams. Yet, the regulating teams were concerned about unresolved trial information and engineers wanted to move at pace. Rather than escalating into dysfunction, these were handled through the **resolution of task conflict** — an approach wherein cross-functional stakeholders were brought together to debate alternatives under the common end game. Task conflict, where managed well, ends in innovation and better decision-making, as compared to relationship conflict, which kills trust.

Pfizer's Ethical Decision Making:

The firm followed a formalized **ethical decision-making procedure** that included:

1. Identifying the ethical problem (e.g., distribution unfairness)
2. Collecting stakeholder perspectives and scientific data
3. Assessing legal, reputational, and operational implications
4. Choosing an action that has multi-level management

5. Real-time monitoring of outcomes and policy adjustments

This same five-step process is consistent with Robbins and Judge's model and was integrated into daily practices in vaccine rollout. One example is the voluntary reporting by the company of tainted material found in a plant in Europe to the public prior to the regulator's action — indicative of proactive instead of reactive ethical behavior.

Organizational Support and Ethics Culture:

Pfizer's actions were also backed by its internal complaint procedures, C-suite level leadership responsibility, and compliance training. The firm rolled out an organization-wide “Speak Up” campaign during the pandemic, which allowed employees to feel at ease and speak up — the tangible commitment to **ethical and psychological safety**.

In 2021 Gallup surveys conducted by an independent organization, 89% of the employees of Pfizer concurred that “leaders at my company do the right thing, even when it’s hard,” significantly higher than industry standards.

Diversity, Inclusion, and Change Management – Building the Future from the Crisis

Along with its scientific and operational achievement, the firm seized the pandemic as an opportunity to drive the agenda of **diversity and inclusion (D&I)** and to effect transformational **organization change**. These endeavors were not secondary to the vaccine introduction — in truth, they were essential drivers of flexibility, resilience, and worldwide trust.

Diversity and Inclusion as Strategy:

Pfizer also understood at an early stage that trust in the vaccine was built through **representative clinical trials**. It reached out to underrepresented populations in 2020 to achieve US Phase 3 trial participants as greater than 42% racial and ethnic minorities (Pfizer, 2021). It established an internal D&I Council to report to the executive team on aspects including hiring, promotions, and team design.

This is parallel to Robbins and Judge's definition of **diversity management** (Chapter 3) as the creation of a culture of inclusion where differences among people are valued and recognized. Pfizer's D&I model was structurally inclusion-focused, as opposed to mere representation — where access, equity, and cultural competency were of utmost importance in the global business.

Post-2020, the company also implemented unconscious bias training for over 80,000 employees and rolled out mandatory inclusive leadership training to all managers. These steps were backed by social identity theory for team cohesiveness: employees are more collaborative and productive when they feel that their identity is accepted and respected.

Lewin's 3-Step Change Model:

In the case of organizational flexibility, Pfizer's move to hybrid work, real-time feedback reports, and flat decision structures followed established principles of **change within an organization** (Chapter 18). Specifically, the company's transformation is an adaptation of **Lewin's 3-step model**:

- **Unfreeze:** Shattering siloed and legacy workflows (for instance, importing trial data into digital boards)

- **Change:** Implementing new systems, decentralization of work, and decentralized decision-making
- **Refreeze:** Codify success into revised SOPs, new KPIs, and team charters

Pfizer also established a “Digital Operations Center” to implement AI and machine learning in supply and production forecasting — an element of the **refreezing phase** that institutionalized innovation.

In 2022, McKinsey recognized Pfizer as one of the best 10 companies to demonstrate “crisis-enabled culture change,” and internal data indicated an increase of 26% in employees' sense of being included since 2019.

Critical Reflection – What Could Be Better?

For all its historic successes, Pfizer's pandemic record was not violated by errors. Robbins and Judge (2019) remind us in their discussion of **emotional intelligence, stress management, and boundaries of organizational behavior** that even high-performing firms need to constantly address how individuals are sustained and supported through crisis conditions.

Burnout and Mental Health Disparities:

With the compressed timelines and around-the-clock deadlines, **burnout** issues at the employee level were the result. Well into 2021, a survey conducted by Pfizer itself discovered that 41% of the employees were “moderate to extremely stressed,” and the digital teams and frontline functions were the most affected. Bonuses and compensated leave worked, but the necessity for **system resilience planning** built into the endeavor became apparent.

Pfizer's topmost priority has always remained success at the mission level, which, critical as it was, came at the cost of **emotional sustainability**. Mid-level managers were caught between the double bind of achieving the results and managing team burnout — a situation wherein emotional intelligence (EQ) (Chapter 4) could have exerted its impact with greater effect.

In response, in 2022, Pfizer included leadership coaching pilots and digital monitoring of wellness. A proactive approach — including mandatory EQ training, enhanced access to EAPs, and safety audits at work — would've made the system preventive instead of reactive.

Supplier Equity and World Justice:

Internal practices of D&I at Pfizer were good but **external collaborations** were less scrutinized. Human rights groups inquired whether subcontractors and worldwide logistics providers were held to equivalent labor and D&I standards in reports. This was a weak area in **supplier governance** and blind spot area in inclusive procurement practices — one which is now under internal review as part of the 2023 ESG roadmap at Pfizer.

Scenario Planning and Predictive Analytics:

Lastly, while Pfizer moved quickly during the crisis, it never **had large-scale predictive infrastructure** pre-crisis. Post-crisis, investment in simulation platforms and uses of AI-driven risk forecasting have picked up, but previous investment would have avoided early response lag.

In sum, Pfizer's OB execution was exemplary — but like any organization, the pandemic revealed improvement areas: deeper EQ support, external ethics consistency, and better foresight tools. These areas form the foundation for the company's next evolution as a resilient, human-centered innovator.

Conclusion – Lessons in Leadership and Organizational Behavior

Pfizer's reaction to the COVID-19 pandemic demonstrates the impact organizational behavior (OB) can have on success, even under high-stakes and ambiguous situations. Its communication, team design, leadership, and motivation practices were all oriented to turn a global health crisis into an opportunity window for resilience and breakthrough.

The critical Robbins and Judge (2019) principles were put into practice at every level – from transformational and courageous leadership to ethical decision-making, safety, and commitment to flexibility and diversity. These were the very same principles that allowed the firm to move quickly, in teams, and with integrity.

The company struggled with supply-chain stress and employee burnout, but its success was the result of something greater than science — it was the result of people, culture, and coordinated execution.

Pfizer's history is an eyeopener to the realization that OB is not an abstract theory — it is actual. Used intentionally, it is an effective tool in crisis management and building long-term resilience.

“In crisis, we reveal who we truly are.”

and Pfizer proved that clearly.

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